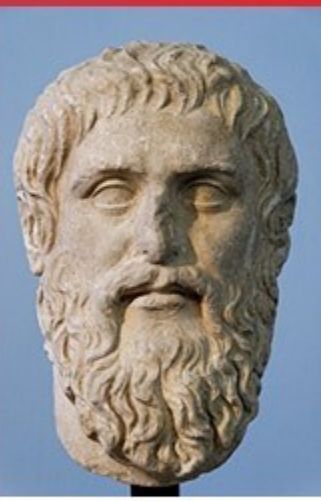
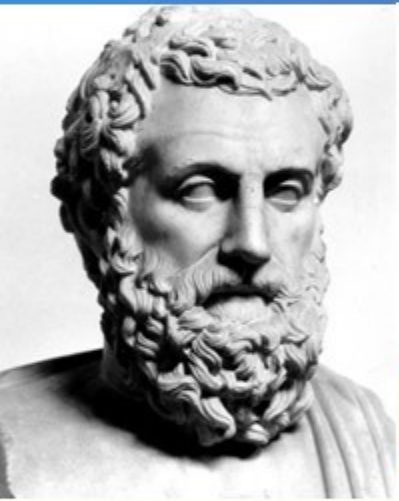


ETHICS, INTEGRITY & APTITUDE



ATTITUDE

MODULE - 17

**CONTENT, STRUCTURE AND
FUNCTION**

STRENGTH



The strength of an attitude can predict behaviour.

The **strength** with which an attitude is held is often a good **predictor of behavior**. The **stronger the attitude** the **more likely** it should **affect behavior**.

Attitude strength involves **importance / personal relevance**. It refers to how significant the attitude is for the person and **relates to self-interest, social identification and value**.

If an attitude has a **high self-interest** for a person (i.e. it is held by a group the person is a member of or would like to be a member of, and is related to a person's values), it is going to be **extremely important**.

STRENGTH



As a consequence, the **attitude** will have a **very strong influence** upon a person's **behavior**. By contrast, an attitude will **not** be **important** to a person if it **does not** **relate** in any way to their life.

The **knowledge aspect** of attitude strength covers how much a person **knows about the attitude object**. People are generally more knowledgeable about topics that interest them and are likely to hold strong attitudes (positive or negative) as a consequence.

Attitudes **based on direct experience** are more **strongly held** and influence behavior more than attitudes formed indirectly (**for example**, through hear-say, reading or watching television).

STRUCTURE OF ATTITUDE

One-dimensional perspective of attitudes: a perspective that perceives positive and negative elements as stored along a single dimension.



Or



An individual with positive feelings, beliefs and behaviours about the Mumbai Indians team is unlikely to have negative feelings, beliefs and behaviours about this team. (One-dimensional perspective)

Another important issue of attitude is about how positive and negative evaluations are organized within and among the affective, cognitive and behavioural components of attitudes (called structure of attitude).

It is typically assumed that the existence of positive feelings, beliefs and behaviours inhibits the occurrence of negative feelings, beliefs and behaviours.

According to this one-dimensional perspective of attitudes, the positive and negative elements are stored in memory at opposite ends of a single dimension, and people tend to experience either end of the dimension or a location in between.

STRUCTURE OF ATTITUDE



Person A, who is plotted on an axis depicting the one-dimensional view, would be **slightly positive**.

ONE-DIMENSIONAL

Two-dimensional perspective of attitudes: a perspective that perceives positive and negative elements as stored along separate dimensions.

This one-dimensional view is opposed by a two-dimensional perspective of attitudes, which suggests that positive and negative elements are stored along two separate dimensions.

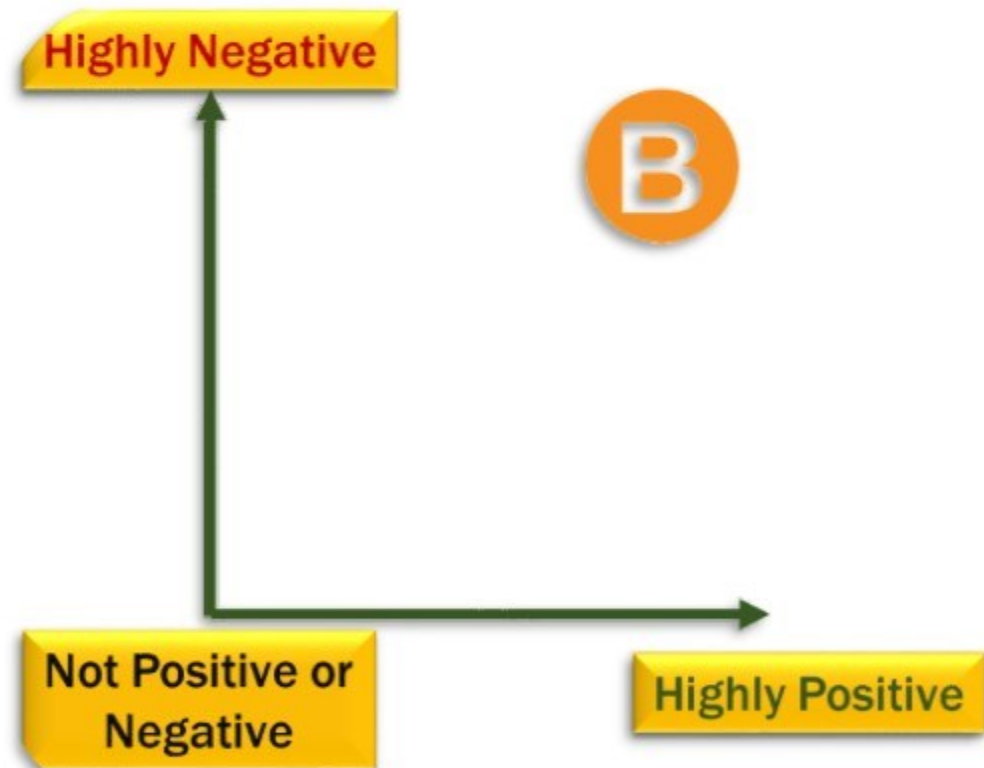
One dimension reflects whether the attitude has few or many positive elements, and the other dimension reflects whether the attitude has few or many negative elements.

This view proposes that people can possess any combination of positivity or negativity in their attitudes.

The single axis does not permit one to mark person A as being both negative and positive.

STRUCTURE OF ATTITUDE

One axis represents variability in negative evaluations and the other axis depicts variability in positive evaluations.



Person **B** in the figure could be considered highly **ambivalent**.

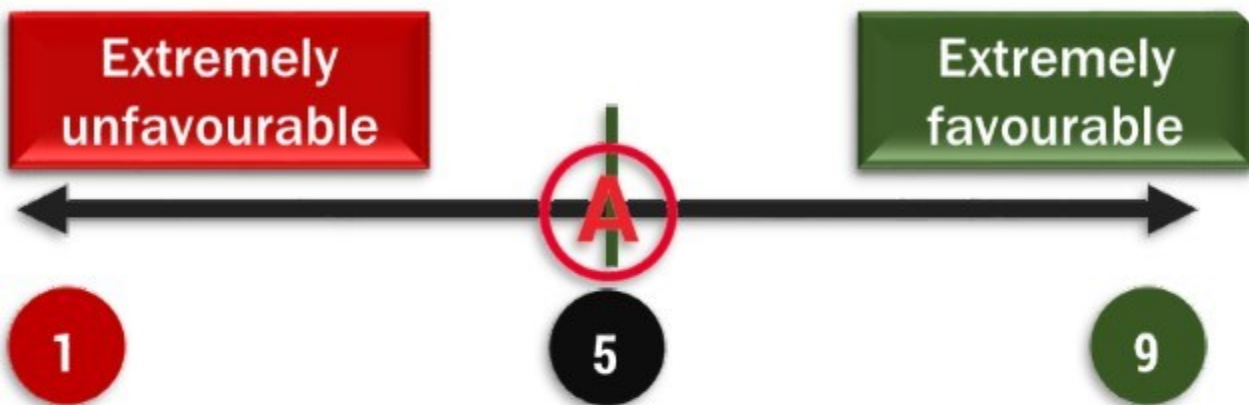
Consistent with the one-dimensional view: attitudes may consist of few positive and many negative elements, few negative and many positive, or few positive and few negative (i.e., a neutral position).

Inconsistent with the one-dimensional view: attitudes might occasionally contain many positive and many negative elements, leading to **attitudinal ambivalence**.

The **two-dimensional** perspective explicitly allows for this ambivalence to occur, whereas the **one-dimensional** perspective does not.

TWO-DIMENSIONAL

STRUCTURE OF ATTITUDE



A **compromise** between many positive and negative elements of their attitude.

They have **no positive or negative elements** whatsoever.

From **two-dimensional** perspective, a person can possess high amounts of **negativity and positivity** towards an object.

At first glance, the **two-dimensional perspective** seems as though it should be **superior** because it allows for the same patterns of positivity and negativity as the one-dimensional view, while also allowing for **ambivalence**.

For instance, it could be **difficult** to interpret the meaning of the **neutral point** in **one-dimensional** scales for assessing attitudes.

Attitudinal ambivalence: an instance where an individual both likes and dislikes an attitude object.

STRUCTURE OF ATTITUDE



RESPONSE POLARIZATION

The **failure** to distinguish between the reasons for a neutral selection is **important**, because measures that directly assess ambivalence predict a variety of outcomes: the best known outcome is **response polarization**.

People who are highly **ambivalent** towards an object are **more strongly influenced by features of their environment that make salient its positive or negative attributes**.

This **causes them to behave** more favourably towards the object when the positive elements are salient than when the negative elements are salient. In contrast, **nonambivalent** people are less strongly influenced by the acute salience of the positive or negative attributes.

Smith (1956) suggested that attitudes serve three primary functions or needs: *object appraisal, social adjustment and externalization.*

Object appraisal refers to the ability of attitudes to summarize the positive and negative attributes of objects in our social world.

All sane people stay away from drugs because they have the ability to understand the negative attributes of drugs.

Social adjustment is fulfilled by attitudes that help us to identify with people we like and to dissociate from people we dislike.

Individuals may choose to buy a certain product because it is promoted by their favourite cricketer.

Externalization is fulfilled by attitudes that defend the self against internal conflict.

People who can't drive a two-wheeler might develop an intense dislike for them because their inability threatens their self-esteem.

ATTITUDE FUNCTION

EXAMPLE

Our attitudes towards the Mumbai Indians team is developed from many of our friends and colleagues supporting the same team. In contrast, our attitudes towards capital punishment are based on the value we place on human life.



EXAMPLE

A person might cycle to work because he values health and wishes to preserve the environment.



ATTITUDE FUNCTION



DANIEL KATZ

Individuals hold attitudes for a variety of reasons.
Attitudes can serve functions for the individual.

Knowledge: Attitudes provide meaning (knowledge) for life. The knowledge function refers to our need for a world which is consistent and relatively stable. This allows us to predict what is likely to happen, and so gives us a sense of control.

Attitudes can help us organize and structure our experience. Knowing a person's attitude helps us predict their behavior.

For example, children whose parents are doctors are more likely to opt for MBBS in their graduation.

ATTITUDE FUNCTION

Adaptive / Utility: If a person holds and/or expresses socially acceptable attitudes, other people will reward them with approval and social acceptance.

When employees flatter their bosses and students their instructors or keep silent if they think an attitude is unpopular.

Expression can be nonverbal [touching the feet of elders]. Attitudes are to do with being a part of a social group and the adaptive functions help us fit in with a social group. People seek out others who share their attitudes, and develop similar attitudes to those they like.

Value / Ego-expression: The attitudes we express (1) help communicate who we are and (2) may make us feel good because we have asserted our identity.

Self-expression of attitudes can be nonverbal too: car stickers, cap, or T-shirt slogans. Therefore, our attitudes are part of our identity, and help us to be aware through the expression of our feelings, beliefs and values.

Attitudes may serve a value-expressive function, such that an attitude may express an individual's self-concept and central values.

Ego-defence: The ego-defensive function refers to holding attitudes that protect our self-esteem or that justify actions that make us feel guilty.

This function has psychiatric overtones. Positive attitudes towards ourselves, for example, have a protective function (i.e. an ego-defensive role) in helping us reserve our self-image.

EXAMPLE

One way children might defend themselves against the feelings of humiliation they have experienced in sports classes is to adopt a strongly negative attitude to all sports.

EXAMPLE

People whose pride has suffered following unsuccessful attempts to learn to drive a two-wheeler might say that they prefer public transportation as it is cheaper or a car because it is comfortable.

The basic idea behind the functional approach is that attitudes help a person to mediate between their own inner needs (expression, defense) and the outside world (adaptive and knowledge).

THE THREE WITCHES

Attitudes towards a brand of car that are based on a need to **gain maximum resale value**.



Although it is **possible** to partly separate the **effects** of attitude structure and attitude function it is true that **they are often related**.

One important question that is relevant to the content, structure and function of attitudes is **the extent to which attitudes are stable over time**. This question is relevant to efforts **to quantify the strength of an attitude**.

These **attitudes** in the example of choosing a particular brand of car are **based on beliefs about the extent to which the car obtains resale value**.

THE THREE WITCHES

Attitudes towards a particular style of clothing fulfill a **psychological need** to **enhance social acceptability**.



*These attitudes are **based on beliefs** about the extent to which the style is **preferred for the occasion**.*

We **feel more strongly** about some topics than about others. individuals can simply be asked **how certain they are** of their attitude, as well as **how important their attitude is to them personally**.

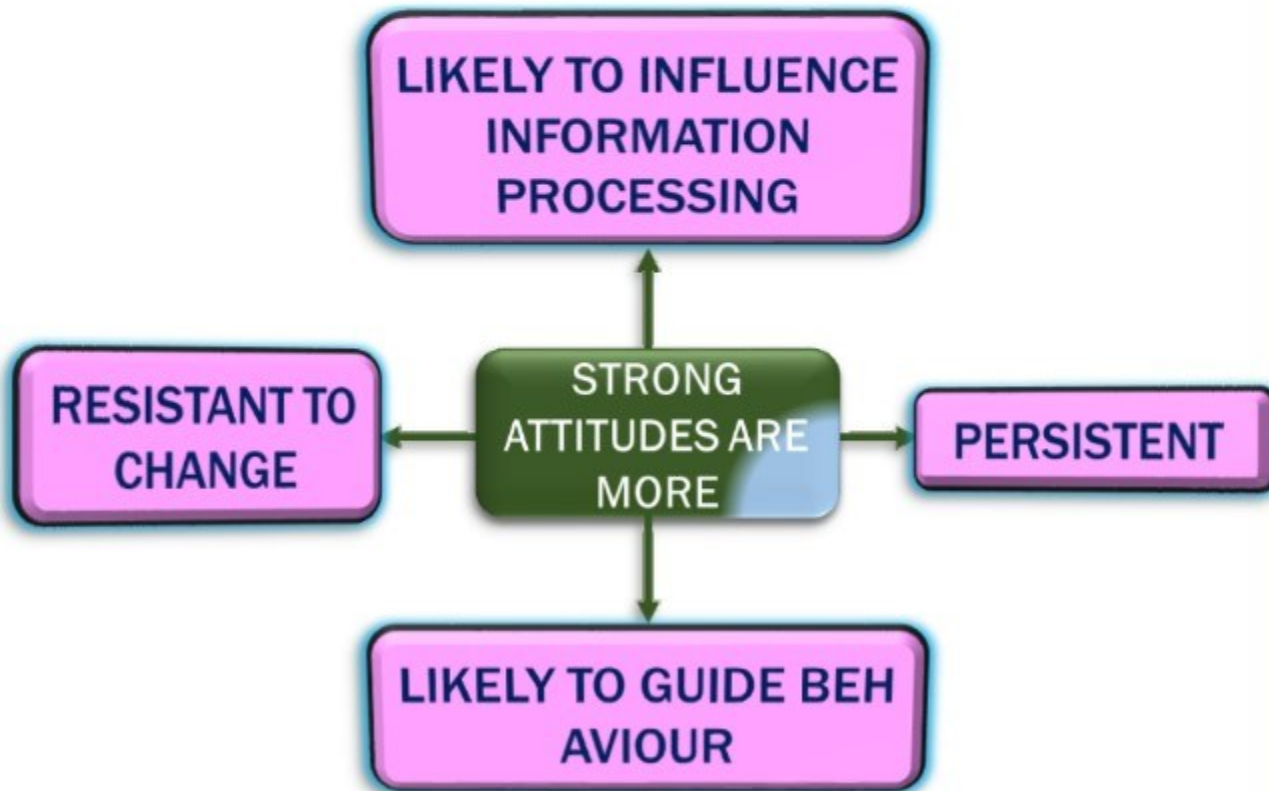
The strength of an attitude can also be measured by **assessing its distance from the middle of a scale**. This type of index, is known as **attitude extremity**.

Similarly, **some** attitudes can be **retrieved from memory more quickly** than others; such easily retrievable attitudes are referred to as **being highly accessible**.

Attitudes that serve **different functions** often **differ in the content of the beliefs** that support them.

THE THREE WITCHES

Strong attitudes differ from weak attitudes in a number of ways. There are **four key manifestations of strong attitudes**.



Strong attitudes **are more persistent**. That is, they are **more temporally stable** over the passage of time.

1

Strong attitudes **are more resistant to change**. When faced with a persuasive appeal, **strong** attitudes are **less likely to change** than weak attitudes.

2

Strong attitudes **are more likely to influence information processing**. Research has revealed that people **devote greater attention to information** that is **relevant to strong attitudes** over weak attitudes.

3

Strong attitudes **are more likely to guide behaviour**. Put simply, we are more likely to **act upon strong attitudes** not weak ones.

4

WE EXPRESS OUR
SINCERE THANKS
FOR VIEWING THIS VIDEO

Presented by



Learning Space

For Suggestions:

suggestions@learningspace.in

To Contact us:

info@learningspace.in

OUR TEAM

G. V. Rao
K. Srikanth
D. Sunil Kumar
L. V. Krishna
Y. Deepthi

Amrita Naidu
M. Binukrishna
G. Ravi Babu
D. Joji
K. Victor Babu

Visit us at:

www.learningspacedigital.com

0 8 6 6 -2 4 4 4 4 7 2
0 9 8 4 9 9 4 2 2 9 9